

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY



ACTOR REPORT

Unmasking Earth Baku: New Tactics and Targets in Cyber Espionage

Date of Publication

August 13, 2024

Admiralty code

A1

TA Number

TA2024310

Summary

Attack Began: 2022

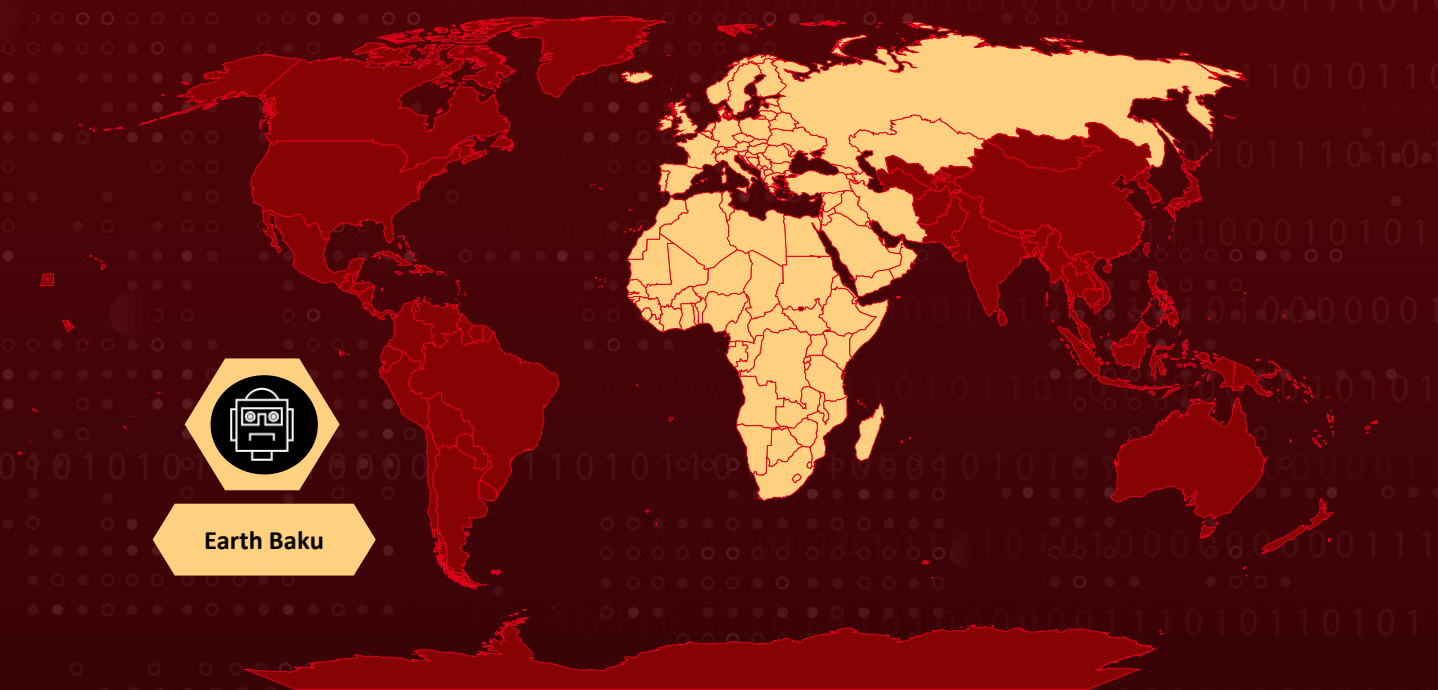
Actor Name: Earth Baku

Targeted Regions: Europe, the Middle East, Africa, Italy, Germany, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Georgia, and Romania

Malware: StealthVector, StealthReacher (aka DodgeBox), SneakCross (aka MoonWalk), and Cobalt Strike

Targeted Industries: Government, Media and Communications, Telecommunications, Technology, Healthcare, and Education

Actor Map



© Australian Bureau of Statistics, GeoNames, Microsoft, Navinfo, Open Places, OpenStreetMap, TomTom, Zenrin
Powered by Bing

Actor Details

#1

Earth Baku, an advanced persistent threat (APT) actor, has recently expanded its operations from the Indo-Pacific region to Europe, the Middle East, and Africa (MEA). This shift includes targeting countries such as Italy, Germany, the UAE, and Qatar, with indications of activity in Georgia and Romania as well.

#2

The group's recent campaigns have broadened their focus, now encompassing critical sectors including government, media, telecommunications, technology, healthcare, and education. They exploit public-facing applications, particularly Internet Information Services (IIS) servers, to gain initial access and deploy sophisticated malware, including the Godzilla webshell, which facilitates further control over compromised systems.

#3

Earth Baku's toolkit has evolved to include advanced loaders like StealthVector and StealthReacher, which utilize AES encryption and code obfuscation techniques to evade detection. The newly introduced SneakCross backdoor leverages Google services for command-and-control operations, enhancing its modularity for updates and functionality. After breaching a system, the group employs various tools for persistence and data exfiltration, including a customized tunneling tool, Rakshasa, and MEGAcmd for transferring stolen data to cloud storage.

#4

Earth Baku's advancements in tactics and tools highlight an evolving threat landscape, necessitating robust cybersecurity measures. Organizations are advised to implement best practices such as the principle of least privilege, regular system updates, and proactive incident response strategies to mitigate risks associated with these sophisticated attacks.



Actor Group

NAME	ORIGIN	TARGET REGIONS	TARGET INDUSTRIES
Earth Baku	Unknown	Europe, the Middle East, Africa, Italy, Germany, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Georgia, and Romania	Government, Media and Communications, Telecommunications, Technology, Healthcare, Education
	MOTIVE		
	Espionage and Information theft		



Recommendations



Strengthen Public-Facing Applications: Regularly update and patch public-facing applications like IIS servers to close vulnerabilities that could be exploited for initial access.



Implement Robust Access Controls: Enforce the principle of least privilege, restricting access to critical systems and data, and closely monitor user permissions to prevent lateral movement by attackers.



Enhance Incident Response Capabilities: Develop and regularly test a proactive incident response plan that includes scenarios involving sophisticated malware, persistence mechanisms, and data exfiltration techniques.



Secure Backup Strategies: Follow the 3-2-1 backup rule, ensuring data backups are stored in different formats, with one copy air-gapped and off-site, and regularly test the integrity of these backups to ensure data can be restored in case of an attack.



Advanced Threat Detection and Response: Deploying advanced threat detection and response solutions is essential for identifying and mitigating sophisticated attacks. This includes using Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) tools, Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS), and Intrusion Prevention Systems (IPS). These tools can detect unusual activity and provide alerts on potential intrusions, allowing for quicker response times.

Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

<u>TA0011</u> Command and Control	<u>TA0002</u> Execution	<u>TA0003</u> Persistence	<u>TA0010</u> Exfiltration
<u>TA0005</u> Defense Evasion	<u>TA0001</u> Initial Access	<u>TA0004</u> Privilege Escalation	<u>TA0007</u> Discovery
<u>TA0040</u> Impact	<u>TA0008</u> Lateral Movement	<u>T1027</u> Obfuscated Files or Information	<u>T1082</u> System Information Discovery
<u>T1055.012</u> Process Hollowing	<u>T1055</u> Process Injection	<u>T1565</u> Data Manipulation	<u>T1056.001</u> Keylogging

<u>T1056</u> Input Capture	<u>T1021.001</u> Remote Desktop Protocol	<u>T1021</u> Remote Services	<u>T1071.004</u> DNS
<u>T1071</u> Application Layer Protocol	<u>T1133</u> External Remote Services	<u>T1068</u> Exploitation for Privilege Escalation	<u>T1059</u> Command and Scripting Interpreter

✂ Indicator of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
MD5	28072e4a3bc3376aba096045824f4c34, 4141c4b827ff67c180096ff5f2cc1474, 72070b165d1f11bd4d009a81bf28a3e5, bc85062de0f70afd44bb072b0b71a8cc, bcac2cbda36019776d7861f12d9b59c4, c33247bc3e7e8cb72133e47930e6ddad, d72f202c1d684c9a19f075290a60920f, e9625ce47b87085b66e0ee6e17ecb333, ee7faba27a2c5f7acb5b06e94aa318e0, f062183da590aba5e911d2392bc29181, f0953ed4a679b987a2da955788737602, f42867e74bbc41767bffacc0de7bfa5e
SHA1	13c1c6752006667697cd4f72a2f1b8616af2b60e, 144550355b3dfb67a0ef65dc7f69470b4faf4ca1, 2cc76a0434a1d489c1547c7021a3dd68499141c3, 2fce25afb8a29fcd526f61ba30f14dcc7ecfad3e, 3872c38625ca62de3bcbe29740c1a0b8921fcf48, 54a0dd2003a6dfc5fd035ba3aabb9fd96b5bd09e, 5b46b63e31f307757cedf305005ce9990a07cbf4, 66fb63e6e49c2c201a0b6204e1d0269812a4b662, 8d8161a7fcd835781820e4921039525975f9324d, a555bb5b6b0e9edf49c4f6bfc8638f155dc1986a, ba6d77f358b4fa00dda5d0e2fdd21c761d154f95, d3fdf103e8585192452bb43e902f009c7bc066a3
SHA256	073b35ecbd1833575fbfb1307654fc532fd938482e09426cfb0541ad87a0 4f75, 07aa971f0791b06dd442d4c7a49c1d3d27a1cbb16602f731e870b5ef50e df69e, 0faddbe1713455e3fc9777ec45adf07b28e24f4c3ddca37586c2aa6b5398 98c0, 166b6dcdac31f4bf51e4b20a7c3f7d4f7017ca0c30fa123d5591e25c3fa66 107,

TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	1c88150ec85a07c3db5f18c5eedcb0b653467b897af01d690ed996e5e07ba8e3, 21fc0f50d545c0a373380934dc61c423c8a31d8c3e6eae4f8a35149ad9962d88, 22a50cea6ad67a7e8582d2cd4cdc3eaaf57c0fbe8cd062a9b15710166e255a86, 3e52c310c6556367ff9e18448bc41719e603d1cbbdafdcba736c6565529617b6, 73eaba82ef1c502448e533007e92b1afa879b09f85f28b71648668ea62839ff5, 7463700ec5768d4af6549028465f978059611555aa8e22e2b7c664b1cdbfa9ae, 7586e58a569c2a07d0b3a710616f48833a040bf3fc57628bbdec7fcb462d565a, 7e63c6b9ab3b32beffbc1eb23d6ca7cc59616b0722f0dd4f0d893c0a1724f5d7, 7f24bc080281d250ec88493e5803e488721a17c9382cd54ba8dfbcb785f23a88, 83de8917bf0ac1d670acf27431015215db872b7291979312dd65e30d99806abb, 8405d742405d3a6d3bda6bc49630dd5f3604a3d6ae27cbd533e425f8abbafdc, a50f85c71b69563ba42bf04c937e1063244ca4957231d3adac76f1c96ab42d3c, ab56501167fe689fe55f6e6ddc3bb91952299bd5c3ef004b02bf1c3b4061c7cf, c02accc26a389397fb172f83258baa8a974986ffd706ba708a3b0a679f61be56, c6a3a1ea84251aed908702a1f2a565496d583239c5f467f5dcd0cfc5bfb1a6db, cdcbd9c25e06ac6da5497fa19459d0007449ec1a3e6bc591334db6fb3598aecb, e4360c0aa995e6e896b22bb7725a6c9b189be8606e7cbbc8b6e80c606358649d, e5f1360d4c299bb32e33e081115f2b520251a983af2ebc649b4b9b70308246fe, ec10a9396dca694fe64366e0dab82d046cf92457f97efd50a68ceb85adef6b74, ec5a96f42aeccdf9a3ae4c3650689606c8539fd65c0b47f30887afecb901be43
IPv4	5[.]182[.]207[.]28, 78[.]108[.]216[.]20, 212[.]87[.]212[.]115
Domains	www[.]mircoupdate[.]https443[.]net, icy-bar-c375[.]microsoft-updates[.]workers[.]dev, www[.]sitennnews[.]com, update-chrome[.]realgodad[.]workers[.]dev,

TYPE	VALUE
Domains	track[.]cdn78544[.]ru, www[.]cdn7854[.]workers[.]dev, shrill-tooth-b557[.]vgfjuic[.]workers[.]dev

References

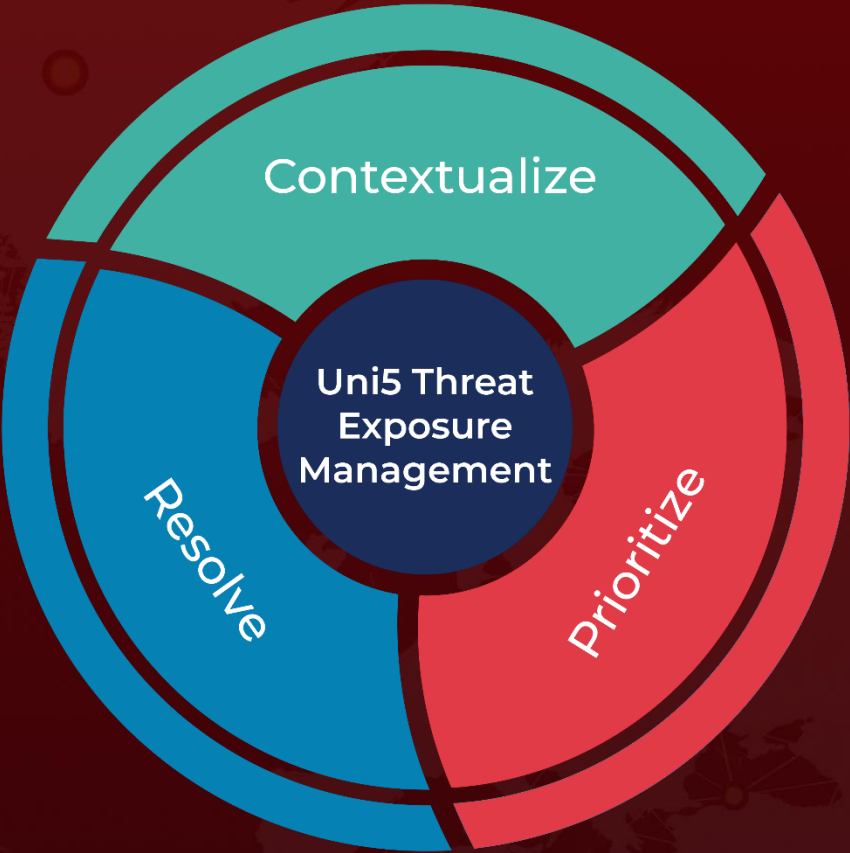
https://www.trendmicro.com/en_us/research/24/h/earth-baku-latest-campaign.html

<https://www.trendmicro.com/content/dam/trendmicro/global/en/research/24/h/earth-baku/ioc-a-dive-into-earth-baku-latest-campaign.txt>

What Next?

At Hive Pro, it is our mission to detect the most likely threats to your organization and to help you prevent them from happening.

Book a free demo with HivePro Uni5: Threat Exposure Management Platform.



REPORT GENERATED ON
August 13, 2024 • 5:30 AM

© 2024 All Rights are Reserved by Hive Pro



More at www.hivepro.com